GAMEXP · DESIGN ANALYSIS PLAY NOTES

Animal Well: Teaching Through Playthings, Pets, and Playgrounds

Lens Metroidvania with a puzzle focus

Design question How does Animal Well help players learn its systems without relying on a conventional tutorial or traditional combat?

Thesis

> Animal Well teaches through interaction rather than explanation. Its toys have distinct physical behaviors, its threats often have to be managed instead of defeated, and its series of micro worlds / playgrounds gives players safe spaces to experiment. Together, these choices make observation, experimentation, and spatial problem-solving lead the progression.

Toys as abilities

The player's tools include a Frisbee, yoyo, slinky, and a bubble wand, none of which are primarily weapons. Each has a physical behavior that can be used in combination with the environment: a Frisbee can bounce and travel across screens, the yoyo can interact with an animal, and the bubble wand can create temporary platforms.

That distinction shapes how the player approaches obstacles. Instead of asking which weapon will remove a threat, the player is encouraged to ask what a toy can do in this space. The toys / tools teach through their effects: when the player receives an item there is always space to experiment. They can then observe the result and consider what context(s) that behavior might be useful for.

> **Design pattern.** Give an object a legible physical behavior, then let players discover situations where that behavior matters.

Threats as navigation problems

Many games make combat encounters puzzles that end when an enemy is defeated. Animal Well often asks a different question: how can the player avoid, distract, or route around a threat?

This changes the role of enemies. A circulating animal, for example, can be treated as an obstacle whose movement must be understood rather than a target to eliminate. The player's task becomes reading the space and choosing when or how to move through it.

The effect is subtle but important: danger becomes part of the environment's logic. Progress can come from understanding and managing a threat, not overpowering or destroying it. Furthermore, these animals might be read less as threats and more like obstacles or organisms to look out for.

Learning by trying: a closer look at the toy interactions

Several of the game's interactions make its teaching approach tangible:

- Riding the Frisbee as it bounces and travels across screens turns its movement into a way of traversing space.
- Using the yoyo with the chinchilla makes the tool's interaction with an animal part of the puzzle.
- The bubble wand can create temporary platforms, turning a tool into a way to shape a route.
- The disc-and-shrine sequences add pressure: the player must use the disc while outrunning a ghost and reaching a destination.

Across these examples, the tool is not merely a key that opens a matching lock. Its behavior becomes part of the challenge. The player has to understand what it does, then apply that understanding while accounting for space, timing, or danger.

Onboarding and world density

The game offers little conventional onboarding: little dialogue, minimal narrative direction, and few explicit instructions. This puts more weight on environmental cues and freedom for experimentation. The player is expected to observe the world and learn by trying things.

The world's density supports that approach. Exploration and progression feel closely connected to space and items rather than to a long quest log or a sequence of unrelated tasks. That keeps the experience focused, though it also means players may have to infer what has changed after an encounter or where a new possibility leads. The game design expects more of the player. Without spelling things out explicitly, the game expects that players will figure it out.

Presentation as atmosphere

The pixel art initially appears simple and almost cute. However, it soon becomes apparent that there are also sophisticated lighting, smoke, and fluid effects happening that give Animal Well a unique look and feel. Also, the darker color palette and understated audio design add more layers, giving the world a slightly unsettling tone.

The contrast matters: familiar animals and household toys occupy spaces that feel eerie, while the player character seems physically underpowered. In my experience, this helped Animal Well create an almost horror-like atmosphere. It was the first Metroidvania since Super Metroid, and to a lesser extent Hollow Knight, where that atmosphere landed so strongly in the realm of a scarier horror game for me.

Where readability breaks

The game's indirectness is effective when experimentation produces understandable feedback and facilitates space for player discovery. It can be more frustrating when the player does not know everything an item can do. For example, the Frisbee has its first-order use of throwing and coming back. But it is not immediately apparent that the player can also ride the Frisbee while it flies and bounces between objects. Further still, I stumbled upon its third-order function of being able to break rock spikes and make certain areas safer to traverse. This seems to be the case for the other items, and there are likely also other uses that I have not discovered yet.

Another example where ambiguity hurts: after the spider boss, I could not tell whether a reward existed or how to claim it. The encounter had ended, but I could not identify what, if anything, had changed. Similarly, I found the human, apartment-like room and large clock at the end difficult to interpret. I liked that the game left a puzzle after the map / main campaign was cleared, but I could not determine how to resolve it or even where to start.

These moments show a useful design tension: withholding instructions can encourage curiosity, but unclear feedback can make experimentation feel directionless. A small cue could help players recognize that a reward or new possibility is available without explaining the puzzle outright.

Design takeaway

> Animal Well shows how a game can teach through the combination of object behavior, environmental space, and player experimentation. Its strongest interactions let players discover what a tool can do and then reuse that knowledge in a new situation.

The design also shows the risk of relying on inference. When the game's feedback goes quiet, players may not know whether they have missed a clue, failed to notice a change, or reached a deliberate mystery. For a game like Animal Well, I think it is great as it is; everything need not be spelled out. However, for my own design practice, one takeaway is to make discovery feel open-ended while still giving players enough feedback to know their actions mattered. Perhaps more explicit descriptions / examples / onboarding early on — at the cost of some freedom, experimentation, and discovery — is worth getting players onboard. Later, after some progress has been made, scaffolds can be removed and players can venture on with fewer or no supports.